

The Attention Merchants PDF

Tim Wu



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The Attention Merchants

How do merchants steal your attention?

Written by Bookey

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About the book

In this information explosion era, people's attention span is dwindling. Whoever catches public attention also catches the business opportunity. However, seizing attention is not something that only happens in contemporary society. The battle for public attention has already begun a century ago. How did merchants benefit from the battle for attention? What changes has the media undergone as a result? How have advertisements evolved over time? How has marketing encroached on every area of our lives? This book will interpret these topics in detail.

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About the author

Tim Wu, the author of this book, was named one of the top 50 science and technology leaders by “Scientific American”, and is ranked among the top 100 most influential graduates of Harvard University. He put forward the theory of "Net Neutrality", and is the person with the most insight into media transformation, network evolution and information. This book explains how the public's attention is harvested through free media and became a realizable commodity over a timespan of 200 years. The author reveals the long-lasting effect of realization from all aspects.

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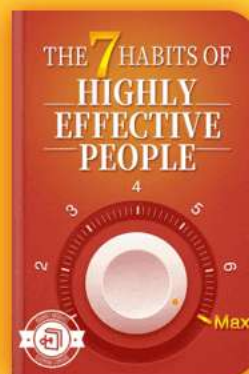
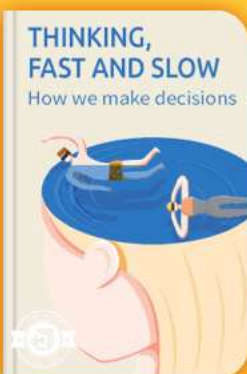


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Chapter 1 : Overview

Hi, welcome to Bookey. Today we will unlock the book “Attention Merchants”: The Epic Scramble to Get Inside Our Heads.

Everyone is familiar with the concept of attention. Both people and animals with normal body functions have the ability to focus their attention at will. This skill can be produced at any time and is inexhaustible. We normally believe that only scarce and non-renewable resources are valuable. However, there is a small group of people who not only view attention as a resource, but also desire to turn this resource into a commodity.

Consider our daily life: In our spare time, we log onto Facebook, listen to music, read push messages, and go to Amazon to fill up our shopping cart. When it's time to be productive, we try to concentrate on our work, but unable to stop ourselves from randomly opening a webpage. The news that pops up is a hot topic we've been following recently. We open Ebay after browsing the news. The front page shows products similar to the one we searched yesterday. Before we know it, it is near noon, and we haven't even started our



work.

Our reliance on electronic products has reached an unprecedented level. We pick up the phone as soon as we open our eyes. When compared to our spouse, our smartphone seems to be a more suitable partner. We feel short of breath and flustered when we are apart from it even for a little while. Why do we react like this? Why is there so much information pouring in every day? In the face of all this information, we are anxious if we don't read them, but we are even more anxious when we do. These electronic resources seem to penetrate our minds and constantly attract our attention.

It might surprise you to hear this, but this is the result of the market's 200 years of continuous efforts to manipulate people's attention. This begs the question, how are they able to control people's minds? What kind of growth has this industry experienced? And what insights can we get from it? The book "Attention Merchants" gives us the answers.

Tim Wu, the author of this book, was named one of the top 50 science and technology leaders by "Scientific American", and is ranked among the top 100 most influential graduates

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of Harvard University. He put forward the theory of "network neutrality", and is the person with the most insight in to media transformation, network evolution and information.

This book explains how the public's attention is harvested through free media and became a realizable commodity over the timespan of 200 years. It then explains how, after attention became a business, media and advertisers competed for the public's attention in this long-running battle. It also shows how the public give out their attention unconsciously. We must now take a look at what life was like about 200 years ago in order to understand the full story.

We are going to unlock this book in detail by dividing it in to three parts.

Part One: Merchants make the attention as a modern business.

Part Two: The increasing competition for people's attention.

Part Three: The Internet is attracting attention everywhere.



Chapter 2 : Merchants make the attention as a modern business

To talk about attention business, let's first talk about what attention really is.

When we were little, ever since we can remember, we were instructed to pay attention about everything we do. We were told to pay attention when we pour a glass of water and pay attention when we are in class. It was drilled into us to pay attention to whatever we do. In other words, paying attention to a task was seen as a way of pleasing our parents and teachers.

However, it seems that we never carefully considered what the true meaning of attention is. It is something that everyone owns and can be lost at any time. In the literal sense, attention refers to what we are looking at, but this is too simplistic. Conceptually speaking, it is the ability to pay attention to objective things, using five information channels, including vision, hearing, touch, smell and taste. Therefore, Russian educator Ushinsky once pointed out incisively that "Attention is the only portal to our soul". That is to say,



external things can only enter our brain through the door of attention. For example, imagine we are attending a conference. The person on stage has been talking passionately for an hour, but we haven't heard anything. The reason is simple. It's because the door of our attention is tightly closed. When we open the door of attention, we can acquire information in a highly effective way. However, when we close it, it is like our souls are blocked. Obviously, this door is very important for humans, so merchants see it as a business opportunity.

So how did merchants turn attention into a business? First, we need to talk about the highly interesting creatures known as humans. It is true that humans are capable of remarkable brainpower, which can continuously promote medical, scientific and technological development. Nowadays, we are able to save countless lives and cure diseases, which could not have been imagined in the past. Not to mention, we can even explore the universe outside of our world. However, one thought has remained consistent throughout centuries. That is the desire for free lunch. If there is a store that gives a discount, or a supermarket that gives free giveaways to celebrate its anniversary... It will surely be crowded with people. Whether it's free cosmetics or free food, everyone



has been faced with this kind of temptation.

Let's think about specific times when this has happened. Have you seen Hermes offering 90% off? Of course not, because Hermes does not need to attract attention by giving a discount. It does not use this kind of marketing strategy. Rational thoughts will always tell us that those giveaways and sales campaigns are just tricks played by businesses to attract attention and induce consumption. Even with this knowledge, people still flock to it, demonstrating their addiction.

This is not an isolated phenomenon. As early as 200 years ago, a guy named Benjamin Day discovered this habit in humans. At that time, newspapers in America were 6 cents per copy, Like Hermes, newspapers were luxury goods that could only be afforded by politicians and social elites. However, Benjamin sold the newspaper at a huge discount. The New York Sun, which he founded, was sold at only one cent per copy. The result could be imagined. People rushed to buy it, and he acquired mass public attention. This is the first thing attention merchants did: they attracted flows. This word simply means to attract a great number of visits. This is not new to modern society, but it seemed quite avant-garde



nearly 200 years ago. There was no concept like advertisements at that time, and advertisements on newspapers were published on bulletin boards in the form of news. There was an especially large amount of bulletins contained in this newspaper. Benjamin Day found that he could also make money by acquiring public attention. He rapidly acquired massive readership with a low price, and sold advertising spaces on the newspaper to companies. Within a year of founding the newspaper, Benjamin Day's business made a profit.

Benjamin's practice had epoch-making significance. People began to realize that attention could become a business. From then on, merchants made great progress in this industry, opening up the attention industry that continues to this day. Meanwhile, merchants also found that attracting flows was the underlying logic of all attention businesses.

This viewpoint was reconfirmed by Paley, who was born in a rich family, almost a century later. In his time, America's national broadcaster, NBC, had a dominant position in the broadcasting industry, and all local stations had to pay if they wanted to broadcast the programs produced by NBC. Paley then took over CBS, which was on the verge of collapse. He



reversed the situation and offered favorable conditions for local stations. Local stations could not only broadcast CBS programs for free, but also got a share of the advertising revenue. The only condition was that they also had to broadcast programs sponsored by advertisers. This method was very effective. Soon CBS threatened NBC's ruling status and grew their market share to match that of NBC's. Paley utilized "offering things for free" as a method of harvesting attention to win the market.

Let's now examine the effects of the attention market. In other words, what competition tricks have media come up with to attract people's attention? To actually make money, it is obviously not enough to just attract visitors. Content is also needed to attract people's interest. For this reason, since Benjamin Day discovered this new market, many newspapers, magazines, posters, radio and other media have launched various content to constantly stimulate and attract people's attention.

For example, newspapers would publish eye-catching news such as, "there are large, winged creatures living on the moon", "The bloody violence affairs at Beverly Hills ", "celebrities' sex scandals that you should know". Posters and



placards attract people's attention with fancy colors, eye-catching advertisements, sexily dressed women and cute babies. Does all this sound familiar? When we think about it carefully, we may notice that, although we live in modern times, these old tricks are still effective: Who are competing for inheritance and who is having a scandal? If there is no such thing, then go find some quarrels and conflicts. There are still a vast amount of content like this in the media. Arousing excitement, presenting hot topics, creating conflict, and offering gossip have been the main methods for attention merchants to dominate our attention. In this way, they have lasted for hundreds of years.

All right, let's summarize this part. We told you that attention is the only portal into the human minds. Since it's so important, merchants try to make money by appealing to "the human minds". Attracting flows is the underlying logic of all attention businesses. Though society has developed so much over time, the current methods media uses to attract attention are still old tricks that have remained unchanged from the last century.

Now that we understand how merchants attract people's attention, let's move onto the next part. As the war advances,



how do attention merchants compete for people's attention?

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Chapter 3 : The increasing competition for people's attention

In the previous part of this Bookey, we learned how media has harvested public attention with various methods. This even includes fooling the public, for example, in order to catch people's attention, some newspapers would post a headline saying that there are human-like creatures living on the moon. In the modern eye, this kind of information seems to be pure misinformation and laughable. However, nearly two hundred years ago, in an era when it was believed that the media only delivered the truth, you can imagine what stories like this meant to people.

The crazy schemes of attention merchants in history are not only limited to this. In the early 20th century, the pharmaceutical industry provided the most funding to the media. Moreover, as there was no food and drug administration at that time, there was often fraud in the marketing of patent medicines.

We must now thank an investigative journalist who looked into this issue. He published an article called "The Great



American Fraud", which revealed many medical scams in full. For example, many patent medicines contained toxic ingredients. Some medicine didn't have the treatment effect publicized by the company, and patients risked worsening their immunity when they took these medicines, ultimately causing them to die faster. Reports like these quickly aroused a resistance from consumers. At this point, people started to realize how much they were fooled by attention merchants. As a result, the government introduced the Food and Drugs Act.

This incident not only caused great damage to merchants legally, but more importantly, it made people realize that media and advertisers were not trustworthy. They not only made money by harvesting attention, but also by fooling the public. The awakening of the public made it difficult for businessmen. In fact, the advertising industry experienced decades of depression starting in the 1930s. This dilemma

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Chapter 4 : The Internet is attracting attention everywhere

First, let's look at "AdWords", a tool that opened up a new era of capturing people's hearts. The Internet industry today is in full swing. Online shopping is the norm now and online celebrities are springing up like mushrooms. It seems like every ordinary person could become an attention merchant through the Internet and earn influence and money from it. In today's Internet world, everyone seems to be equal.

However, in the early days of Internet development, it did not have the conditions favorable for attention merchants. At that time, almost no one could earn money on the Internet. As soon as the Internet appeared, intuition told businesses that it would be a good place to harvest attention.

Accordingly, many businesses swarmed for their share of the cake.

Blogs, chatting rooms, The Huffington Post, different forms of network application soon attracted large numbers of users. Oddly enough, businesses soon found that users had reached this point but advertisers hadn't. Why was that? This is because advertisers found that the bombardment of push ads



not only had no effect, but also caused users to feel aversion, so they were unwilling to pay. The situation was quite awkward at that time. The Internet was indeed good, but made no money.

At that time, a technology talent who also hated advertising broke the dilemma. His name was Larry Page. At this time, there were a lot of search engines in the market. The layout was mainly used to display advertisements and earn money through advertising. However, Page believed that search engines should be neutral, and should have an artistic and practical style. It was not that advertisements should not be pushed, but that it was necessary to choose the appropriate time. He thought that only pushing the necessary advertisements when consumers were in need of them could make it a win-win situation. He founded Google, and Google's search algorithm was designed so that advertisements are pushed only when people search for keywords with obvious intentions, such as "male hair loss" and "quit smoking". He was also very responsible towards advertisers' spend. In the design of the system, data statistics for advertising click rates were added, and advertisers were charged according to the click rate. Since the promotion was so effective, advertisers were willing to pay.



At that time, Google was equivalent to the last mile between businesses and consumers on the Internet. The service truly reached the terminal, meeting users' needs and making a huge profit for itself at the same time. It can be seen that good products and effective communication can better capture people's hearts and truly play to the advantages of the Internet.

The keyword advertisements mentioned earlier are widely used on the Internet nowadays. If we need something, we can just search for the products we want on the Internet. The Internet empowered customers and also empowered the Internet media era. As a result, we have now entered the best and worst era ever. The origin of this era started with the advent of Facebook.

Actually, when compared to earlier blogs, Facebook did not make a technological breakthrough. However, while blogs have since been kicked out of the game, Facebook has maintained its popularity. What Facebook mainly offered people was a reliable network. As long as you are willing to make friends, you could get hundreds of friends through Facebook.



After obtaining initial success, Facebook made another commercially smart move, which was to acquire Instagram. On Instagram, you can not only post texts, pictures and videos, but can also edit them carefully. It was a great addition for Facebook. With the popularity of smartphones, everyone can use a small phone to create a fascinating image in the virtual world of the Internet. The lucky ones can even attract thousands of followers and get a share of Instagram's advertising income. All this made the word "brand" mean something not only owned by businesses, but also by individuals. The functions of likes and forwards also made it easy for Facebook to collect users' interests and hobbies, so as to push ads accordingly. However, it's worth considering, do they actually serve the public or steal individual privacy? The author comments on this by saying: "Online tracking technologies evolved to a point that would have made a Soviet-era spy blush."

In the past, attracting attention was the business of advertisers and media. And nowadays it's everyone's business. It can be said that the attention industry created more possibilities for people to gain financial freedom. At the same time, in the era of information overload, we must



study the relationship between human anxiety and the intensity of information acquisition. Human brains need time to process information. If too much is obtained at once, it will cause panic. Just like when restaurant waiters get anxious when they handle too many orders at the same time, this kind of panic will cause anxiety.

Every time we turn on the computer and pick up our cellphone, all kinds of push notifications flow in. There are so many notifications to be cleared, which not only affects the user experience, but also makes us lose our focus. We feel like time is passing so quickly every day, but we aren't living a more efficient life. Research has found that continuously browsing too much information makes people unconsciously lose self-control. If we don't control the amount of information we're processing, we could lose attention at any time.

Thus, in an era of information overload, how can we control what we direct our attention to? The author argues that consumers are always at a disadvantage in this war. Moreover, history tells us that, as long as the market exists, there is no end in sight. With the arrival of the Internet, are we actually in the best or the worst era? This is not the key



point that the author wants to make. The book wants to teach us the tricks used by the merchants to harvest our attention. It wants to remind us that when businesses turn attention into a resource, we should consciously reclaim our attention and obtain a higher quality of life through self-control and time management.

This is easy to say but hard to put into action. This is because attention merchants never leave us alone. Maybe we must make a timetable or a plan we are willing to stick to. For example, we could read a book after turning off our phones every night, or we could put down electronic devices to spend time with our family every weekend.

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Chapter 5 : Summary & Review

We have now covered the contents of this Bookey. Let's review and summarize what we've learned.

From Part 1, we understand that attention is the only portal to access people's minds. Since media and advertisers found this important commodity, they've been honing their craft over two hundred years. They turn attention into a business using schemes like free gifts and discounts, creating topics and gossip, and causing excitement and conflicts.

In Part 2, we learned that, after realizing the fraud of media and advertisers, consumers started waking up, which led to a depression in the advertising industry. This lasted until the advent of TV, when advertisers found a new method to compete for people's attention. Meanwhile, media and advertisers found that it was not enough to just attract people's attention. They could only sustain their business by accurately advertising to and building brand loyalty in the right target group.

From the last part we have seen that, in the new Internet era, technological advances enabled attention merchants to



upgrade their advertising techniques. They easily acquired people's private information and attract people's attention. The high intensity information acquisition caused anxiety among people and led people to consider the ethics behind attention businesses.

Looking at this book as a whole, the author finally points out that, in today's Internet era, everyone can become an attention merchant. It is not important whether advertising and marketing is good or bad. The times are advancing. For attention merchants, it is important to sell good products and to realize a win-win situation by mastering the means of attracting people's minds. Only in this way can they make their businesses long-lasting. For us, the key point is to enjoy the benefits of information diversification, but also to pursue awareness by practicing effective time management and self-control.

